RESEARCH PAPER

Ireland’s Maritime Security

Framework in a Changing Strategic Environment

Ireland’s 880,000 km² of Atlantic EEZ, its position as the western terminus of the transatlantic cable network, and the largest unmonitored maritime domain in Europe — examined through the lens of capability, policy, and the 2026 EU Presidency window.

Security Ireland

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KEY FINDINGS

Ireland’s maritime domain is one of Europe’s largest and least monitored. The Exclusive Economic Zone covers approximately 880,000 km² of the northeast Atlantic. Over twenty subsea cables make landfall on Irish shores, carrying approximately 75% of transatlantic data traffic. Yet Ireland’s capacity to monitor this domain has, until 2025, been near zero. The first National Maritime Security Strategy, published in February 2026, establishes a 41-objective roadmap. The €1.5 billion defence budget, towed array sonar procurement, and EU Presidency chairmanship create a convergence of capability investment and political opportunity that did not exist twelve months ago.

The strategic environment

Ireland occupies a maritime position that is, in European strategic terms, irreplaceable. Its Exclusive Economic Zone extends 200 nautical miles from the coast, covering approximately 880,000 square kilometres of the northeast Atlantic[1] — more than ten times the island's land area and one of the largest EEZs in Europe. This zone encompasses shipping lanes critical to European trade, waters where Russian submarine activity has increased since 2014, and the western terminus of the transatlantic cable network.

Approximately 75% of all transatlantic subsea cables pass through or close to Irish waters[2]. These cables carry the vast majority of EU–US data traffic and an estimated $10 trillion in daily financial transactions. The Celtic Interconnector — a 700 MW HVDC power cable to France — is under construction. The Far North Fiber and Pisces cable will add further connectivity.

Ireland is becoming a more critical node in European infrastructure, not a less critical one. Yet the gap between geographic responsibility and operational capability has historically been the largest in Europe.

[1] Marine Institute, "Ireland's Ocean Economy," 2024. Ireland's EEZ covers approximately 880,000 km².

[2] CSIS, "The Strategic Future of Subsea Cables: Ireland Case Study," 2025.

Ireland's maritime domain

The gap between geographic responsibility and operational capability

880,000 km²
Exclusive Economic Zone
10× Ireland's land area

75%
Transatlantic cables through Irish waters

8 vessels
Naval Service fleet
No underwater detection until 2027

0.45%
Defence spending (% GDP)
Lowest in Europe

KEY CABLE ROUTES

Celtic Interconnector (France, under construction) · Far North Fiber (Norway–Alaska–Japan, 2026) · Pisces (France–Portugal–Spain)
14 active transatlantic connections · $10 trillion daily financial transactions · 90% EU–US data traffic

Capability baseline

Naval Service fleet

The Naval Service operates eight active vessels: four Samuel Beckett-class offshore patrol vessels, two large patrol vessels, and two inshore patrol vessels commissioned September 2024. The Multi-Role Vessel programme is being reoriented toward a combat-capable design. Three OPVs are being upgraded with Thales CAPTAS towed array sonar[3], giving Ireland its first underwater detection capability from 2027.

Maritime domain awareness

Ireland lacks comprehensive radar coverage. The primary radar programme targets 2028. The Air Corps is integrated into CISE since April 2025, but Ireland does not yet have an integrated system fusing vessel tracking, naval radar, CISE data, bilateral intelligence, and satellite imagery.

Personnel

Naval Service strength reached 807 at end-2025 — a 12% increase and the first year recruitment exceeded discharges[4]. The target is 1,794 by 2028, requiring approximately 330 recruits per year.

[3] Commission on the Defence Forces, Final Report, 2022. Recommended Level of Ambition 2 by 2028.

[4] Department of Defence, Budget 2026 Estimates. Defence allocation of €1.5 billion.

Capability timeline

Key milestones in Ireland's maritime security transformation, 2024–2028

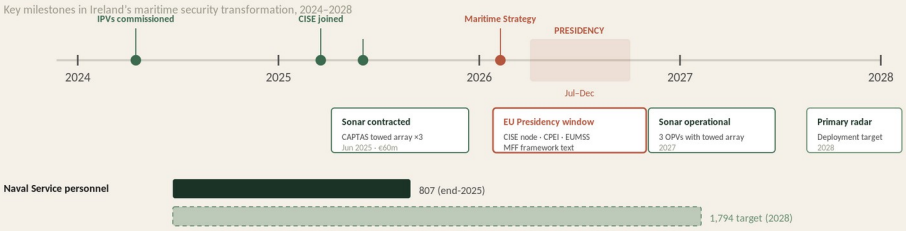

Figure 2: Capability timeline. Green markers indicate completed milestones; terracotta indicates the EU Presidency window and strategic actions.
The convergence of sonar procurement, the first Maritime Security Strategy, and the Presidency creates a window that will not recur for at least a decade.

The policy framework

National Maritime Security Strategy

Ireland's first National Maritime Security Strategy was published 25 February 2026[5]. It establishes 41 objectives across 2026–2030: maritime domain awareness, critical infrastructure protection, hybrid threats, and international cooperation. Key measures include legislation for Naval Service boarding powers[6], a National Maritime Centre, and forward operating bases.

Commission on the Defence Forces

The 2022 Commission recommended Level of Ambition 2 by 2028[7]. As of December 2025, 54 recommendations completed. It recommended three additional vessels, a Multi-Role Vessel, and subsea monitoring systems.

Defence budget

The 2026 budget of €1.5 billion is an 11% increase[8]. A separate €1.7 billion naval modernisation plan covers vessels, sensors, and infrastructure. At 0.45% of GDP, Ireland remains the lowest defence spender in Europe.

> **THE SPENDING CONTEXT** Ireland ranks last among 38 European nations. The gap reflects decades of underinvestment. The question is whether spending increases reach capability or are absorbed by personnel costs.

EU frameworks being shaped

Four EU frameworks govern maritime surveillance. All four are being shaped during Ireland's Presidency (July–December 2026).

[5] Naval Service recruitment data, February 2026. Personnel strength: 807 at end-2025.

[6] Government of Ireland, National Maritime Security Strategy, 25 February 2026.

[7] Thales CAPTAS towed array sonar contracted at approximately €60 million, June 2025.

[8] EU Cable Action Plan, February 2025. €1 billion in CEF Digital funding.

EU frameworks being shaped during Ireland's Presidency

Four maritime surveillance decisions Ireland chairs. All determine whether Ireland's Atlantic geography becomes a permanent European security asset.

CISE

Maritime data sharing

Operational phase; classified network live since late 2025

IRELAND'S MOVE

Propose Atlantic node at NMCC

Sep 2026

Cable Action Plan

€1bn subsea security

CPEI list being drafted; CEF Digital funding open

IRELAND'S MOVE

Designate Irish cable routes as CPEIs

Oct 2026

EUMSS

Maritime Security Strategy

Progress report due Oct 2026; Ireland chairs Council

IRELAND'S MOVE

Draft conclusions naming Atlantic as priority

Oct 2026

MFF Defence Chapter

7-year EU budget

Framework text being drafted; expected by Christmas 2026

IRELAND'S MOVE

Name maritime surveillance as priority domain

Dec 2026

Figure 3: Four EU frameworks being shaped during Ireland's Presidency (July–December 2026). Each represents a structural opportunity to lock in Ireland's maritime role permanently.

CISE. The Common Information Sharing Environment connects European maritime surveillance. The strategic question: does Ireland propose hosting the Atlantic node, or remain a consumer?

EU Cable Action Plan. €1 billion in CEF Digital funding[9]. Ireland should lead the Atlantic basin response and secure CPEI designation for its cable routes.

EUMSS. Progress report due October 2026. Ireland chairs the Council. The conclusions can name Atlantic surveillance as a priority — or focus on Mediterranean and Baltic.

MFF. If maritime surveillance is named in the next seven-year EU budget, Ireland's geography has a permanent funding pathway.

The threat picture

Three categories of threat have moved from assessment to operational stage in Irish waters.

[9] National Maritime Security Strategy: legislation to broaden Naval Service boarding powers.

The threat picture

Three categories of threat have moved from assessment to operational stage in Irish waters

SUBSEA RECONNAISSANCE

Russian vessel Yantar escorted from Irish Sea (Nov 2024) after patrolling above subsea cables with drones.

Shadow fleet vessel near cable (Mar 2025). Mapping ongoing since 2014.

SHADOW FLEET

Russia's sanctions-evasion tankers transit Irish waters. Uninsured cargo, disabled AIS, environmental and

security risks. Naval Service currently lacks powers to board and inspect.

HYBRID INFRASTRUCTURE ATTACK

Baltic cable sabotage (2023–24) demonstrated vulnerability. Ireland's 14 cable connections carry majority

of EU–US data. High-value target with no protective measures yet.

Figure 4: Three operational threat categories in Irish waters. Ireland's lack of underwater detection has made its EEZ a permissive environment for hostile reconnaissance.

What Ireland should lock in

The EU Presidency creates a six-month window. Four actions, each designed to create permanent structures.

1. Propose hosting the Atlantic CISE node

Host the Atlantic surveillance node at the NMCC — fusing Naval Service tracking, towed array data, bilateral UK intelligence, and EU satellite imagery. A data provider is a permanent role; a consumer is dispensable.

> **THIS LOCKS IN:** *Ireland as the Atlantic maritime data hub.*

2. Ensure CPEI designation for Irish cables

Far North Fiber, Celtic Interconnector, and Pisces should be designated Cable Projects of European Interest. CPEI brings CEF Digital funding, enhanced protection, and permanent recognition.

> **THIS LOCKS IN:** *Ireland's cable infrastructure as a named EU strategic asset.*

3. Shape the EUMSS Council conclusions

Ireland chairs the Council receiving the EUMSS progress report in October 2026. Name Atlantic maritime surveillance as a priority — or the Atlantic falls off the agenda.

> **THIS LOCKS IN:** *Atlantic surveillance as a named priority in EU maritime policy.*

4. Embed maritime surveillance in the MFF

Name maritime surveillance in the defence chapter of the next seven-year budget. A permanent funding pathway.

> **THIS LOCKS IN:** *Ireland's maritime geography as a permanent EU budget category.*

What CISE integration looks like for Ireland

Ireland's data sources feed into a CISE Atlantic node, serving EU agencies and member state navies

Figure 6. CISE integration architecture. The question is whether Ireland becomes a data provider (permanent role) or just a consumer (dispensable).

What Ireland locks in — and what it loses

The difference between active and passive chairing of the 2026 EU Presidency

ACTIVE CHAIRING — Locks in

- Atlantic CISE node: Ireland becomes the data hub
- CPEI designation: cables are named EU strategic assets
- EUMSS conclusions name Atlantic surveillance
- MFF includes maritime domain as funding category

RESULT: Permanent funded European security role

vs

PASSIVE CHAIRING — Loses

- × CISE Atlantic coverage depends on data Ireland doesn't provide
- × Cable monitoring led by Nordic states, not Ireland
- × EUMSS focus: Mediterranean and Baltic only
- × MFF defence chapter funds air and ground, not maritime

RESULT: 880,000 km² remains Europe's blind spot

Figure 5: The structural outcomes of active vs passive chairing. Active chairing creates permanent institutional positions; passive chairing leaves the architecture to others.

Risks and gaps

Personnel. Growth from 807 to 1,794 by 2028 requires sustained recruitment never achieved historically.

Procurement. Radar, MRCV, and sonar integration all target 2027–2028. Slippage undermines Presidency credibility.

Institutional depth. The NMSS has 41 objectives but the National Maritime Centre doesn't exist yet.

Spending. At 0.45% GDP, personnel costs absorb 58%. Without sustained capital commitment, modernisation is a one-off.

Recommendations

#	Action	What it locks in
1	Atlantic CISE node at NMCC	Maritime data hub
2	Irish cables as CPEIs	EU strategic asset
3	EUMSS: Atlantic priority	EU maritime policy
4	Maritime in MFF text	EU budget category
5	Recruit 330/year	Crewing capacity
6	National Maritime Centre	Institutional home

Conclusion

Ireland's maritime security framework is being transformed. The convergence of the first National Maritime Security Strategy, record defence investment, sonar procurement, CISE integration, and the EU Presidency creates a window that will not recur for at least a decade.

The question is whether Ireland converts geographic position into institutional position before December 2026. The four recommended actions create permanent structures. Permanent structures outlast political windows.

Ireland's 880,000 square kilometres of Atlantic EEZ is either a funded European security asset or Europe's blind spot. The framework is now in place to determine which.

A NOTE ON METHOD This paper draws on publicly available government publications, EU framework documents, and parliamentary records. It does not assess classified operational matters.

Part of the Security Ireland research series. Companion papers: PESCO and Ireland; ReArm Europe; Maritime Surveillance Cooperation; Hybrid Threats and Cyber Defence.

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